commitment to Kohl to appear at Bitburg. The decision did not fully appease critics and further incensed those who saw Reagan's visit as a form of hastened closure and forgiveness, an offering of shared identification with both victims and perpetrators of World War II.[18]

On May 5, President Reagan laid two wreaths 220 miles apart: one at the base of an obelisk at Bergen-Belsen and another above the tombs of buried German soldiers at Bitburg. Reagan issued remarks at the Bitburg airbase later in the day, to put his two gestures of commemoration in perspective. After making brief remarks to address "veterans and families of American servicemen who still carry the scars and feel the painful losses of that war" and "survivors of the Holocaust," Reagan defended his overall mission to honor U.S.–West German post–World War II relations. To accentuate his point, his speech sampled a famous declaration of identification with Berlin, conveying the importance of this transatlantic diplomatic relationship: "Twenty-two years ago President John F. Kennedy went to the Berlin Wall and proclaimed that he, too, was a Berliner. Well, today freedom-loving people around the world must say: I am a Berliner. I am a Jew in a world still threatened by anti-Semitism. I am an Afghan. And I am a prisoner of the gulag. I am a refugee in a crowded boat foundering off the coast of Vietnam. I am a Laotian, a Cambodian, a Cuban, and a Miskito Indian in Nicaragua. I, too, am a potential victim of totalitarianism."[19]

Reagan's rhetorical approach was to conjure myriad identifications through equivalence and, like Kennedy, claim status as a Berliner. But Reagan extended the identification with Berlin to accommodate a host of other Cold War strategic alliances and disputes through the series of "I am" statements. By mentioning the Holocaust and the Berlin Wall in the same statement and joining them with other geopolitical identities, he attempted to personalize and stand in for a litany of "victims" in Cold War hot spots—without identifying his own administration's participatory or aggressive role in cultivating these global conflicts. Further, he did so without defining the particular forms of suffering and culpability evident in each context. Beyond reconciliation, West Germany was to be affirmed publicly as a crucial military partner in the Cold War and as a site of valid American and NATO armament. To be at once a Berliner, a Jew, a Vietnamese refugee, and a prisoner of a Soviet gulag is an appeal to identification without difference and a justification for increased military action in and through West Germany. Leveraging an identity as a symbolic Berliner—in presence or